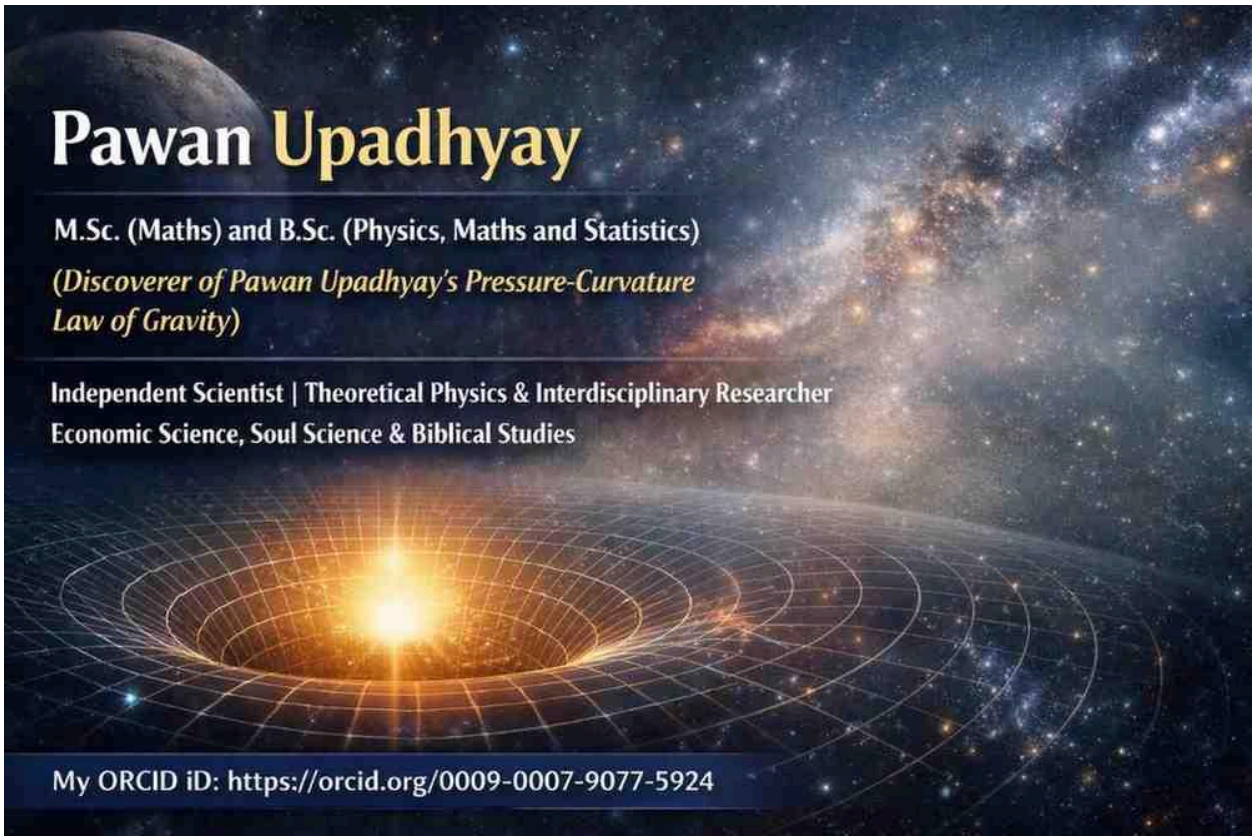
Council and Counsel

A Word Study of the Council of Ungodly People and the Counsel of Ungodly People

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Abstract

The English words **council** and **counsel** are closely related in sound but differ significantly in meaning. *Council* normally refers to a group of people assembled or appointed to deliberate, advise, govern, or make decisions. *Counsel* refers primarily to advice, guidance, direction, deliberation, or a plan. This distinction becomes particularly important when studying the biblical expression **"counsel of the wicked/ungodly"** in Psalm 1:1.

Psalm 1:1 does not use a Hebrew word meaning a formal council or assembly. The Hebrew noun **עֵצָה (ʿēṣâ)** means counsel, advice, plan, purpose, consultation, or guidance, depending on context. In Psalm 1:1, it is specifically associated with the wicked and is commonly translated "counsel of the wicked" or "counsel of the ungodly."

This paper therefore distinguishes two related but different concepts. The **counsel of ungodly people** concerns the advice, values, ideas, plans, influence, and direction through which ungodliness can shape a person's thinking and conduct. The **council of ungodly people**, by contrast, describes an assembly, group, or social body composed of ungodly people. The latter can be a legitimate descriptive phrase in a broader theological discussion, but it should not be presented as the lexical meaning of Psalm 1:1.

The distinction also allows for a broader theological study of how ungodly counsel can operate within an ungodly social environment. A group may produce or reinforce ungodly counsel, while ungodly counsel may influence individuals even without a formal council or gathering. The study concludes that **counsel concerns the influence or guidance being followed, while council concerns the people or body providing or deliberating over such guidance**.

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1. Introduction

Words that sound similar can easily be confused, especially when they occur in theological writing.

Two such words are:

- **council**
- **counsel**

Although they are pronounced similarly, they do not have the same meaning.

This distinction becomes especially important when discussing Psalm 1:1 and the expression commonly translated:

"the counsel of the wicked"

or

"the counsel of the ungodly."

The question is therefore:

Does Psalm 1:1 refer to a council of ungodly people, or does it refer to the counsel of ungodly people?

The answer requires a distinction between the English words and an examination of the Hebrew text.

The central argument of this paper is:

Council refers primarily to a group or assembly of people, whereas counsel refers primarily to advice, guidance, direction, deliberation, plan, or purpose. In Psalm 1:1, the Hebrew term refers to counsel rather than a formal council.

This distinction does not mean that groups of ungodly people are irrelevant to the theological discussion. Groups can influence individuals, develop shared values, reinforce ungodly thinking, and participate in hostility toward godly people. However, these are broader theological applications and should not be confused with the basic lexical meaning of the word in Psalm 1:1.

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2. The English Word “Council”

The English noun **council** refers to a group of people who are gathered, appointed, or elected for a particular purpose, especially to deliberate, advise, govern, or make decisions. Cambridge, for example, defines *council* in relevant senses as a group of people chosen or elected to give advice or make decisions.

Examples include:

- city council,
- church council,
- governing council,
- council of elders,
- academic council,
- advisory council.

The essential concept is **a body of people**.

For example:

The council met to discuss the matter.

Here, *council* refers to the people who assembled.

The word therefore answers the question:

Who is gathered or acting as a deliberative body?

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3. The English Word “Counsel”

The English noun **counsel** refers primarily to **advice, guidance, direction, recommendation, or a considered plan**.

Cambridge's thesaurus associates *counsel* with terms such as advice, guidance, recommendation, suggestion, consultation, and advisement.

For example:

He followed the counsel of his friend.

Here, *counsel* refers to the advice or guidance received.

The word therefore answers the question:

What advice, guidance, or direction is being given or followed?

Counsel can also function as a verb:

The teacher counseled the student.

In this usage, it means to give advice or guidance.

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4. Council and Counsel: The Basic Difference

The difference can be summarized simply:

Word	Meaning	Primary focus
Council	A group or assembly	**The people**
Counsel	Advice, guidance, direction, plan	**The advice/influence**

A useful way to remember the distinction is:

Council = the group.
Counsel = the guidance.

For example:

The council gave counsel.

This sentence demonstrates the distinction perfectly.

The **council** is the group.

The **counsel** is the advice or guidance provided by that group.

Therefore, a council can **give counsel**, and people can **follow counsel** without there being a formal council.

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5. The Hebrew Word in Psalm 1:1

The distinction becomes especially important in Psalm 1:1.

The Hebrew phrase translated “counsel of the wicked” contains the noun **עֵצָה (*ʿēṣâ*, Strong's H6098)**.

Lexical sources give meanings including:

- counsel,
- advice,
- plan,
- purpose,
- consultation,
- prudence,
- strategy,
- design.

The word therefore has a broader semantic range than merely “advice,” but its central conceptual field concerns **counsel, guidance, deliberation, and plans**.

Psalm 1:1 specifically uses this Hebrew noun in the expression translated:

“the counsel of the wicked.”

The lexical entry for Psalm 1:1 identifies the word as **עֵצָה (*ʿēṣâ*)**, meaning counsel or advice.

Therefore, the Hebrew word in Psalm 1:1 should not be understood as the English noun **council**, meaning an organized group of people.

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6. Counsel in Psalm 1:1

Psalm 1:1 presents a person who does not:

walk in the counsel of the wicked.

The important concept is therefore **direction**.

Counsel provides a direction in which someone may walk.

This gives the passage an important theological dimension.

A person encounters counsel.

The person considers the counsel.

The person accepts or rejects the counsel.

If the person accepts the counsel, that counsel can influence decisions.

Decisions can influence conduct.

Conduct can eventually shape a way of life.

Thus:

Counsel → influence → decisions → conduct → way of life.

This is consistent with the imagery of Psalm 1:1, where “walking” is associated with the counsel of the wicked.

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7. What Is the “Counsel of the Ungodly”?

The phrase **“counsel of the ungodly”** can therefore be defined as:

The advice, guidance, values, plans, ideas, and influence that arise from or are consistent with an ungodly way of thinking and that lead a person away from God's ways.

Counsel does not have to be a direct spoken command.

It can include:

- advice given by another person,
- values promoted by a group,
- ideas repeatedly communicated,
- assumptions about happiness,
- attitudes toward God,
- attitudes toward sin,
- worldly definitions of success,
- encouragement to pursue sinful desires,
- or guidance that places created things above God.

Therefore, counsel can influence a person even when nobody explicitly says:

“Reject God.”

A worldview can communicate that message indirectly.

---

8. Counsel Is Not Necessarily Spoken Advice

A narrow understanding of counsel would limit it to someone verbally giving advice.

The biblical concept is broader.

Because *ʿēṣâ* can also mean plan, purpose, strategy, or design, counsel can involve a person's or group's **way of thinking about what should be done**.

For example, a person may follow an ungodly counsel by adopting the belief:

“Money is the ultimate source of security.”

That belief can influence decisions.

Another person may accept:

“Pleasure is more important than obedience to God.”

That idea can influence conduct.

Another may accept:

“There is no need to listen to God's wisdom.”

That attitude can influence the direction of life.

Thus, counsel can operate at the level of **ideas, values, plans, and worldview**, not merely spoken advice.

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9. What Is a “Council of Ungodly People”?

The expression **“council of ungodly people”** is different.

It would describe an **assembly, group, body, or gathering of people characterized by ungodly beliefs, purposes, or conduct**.

For example:

“The council of ungodly people gathered to discuss how they would oppose the godly community.”

In this sentence, *council* refers to the group itself.

The statement is grammatically and conceptually different from:

“The counsel of the ungodly influenced the young man.”

In the second sentence, *counsel* refers to the influence or advice.

Thus:

Council = who is gathered.

Counsel = what is advised, planned, or followed.

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10. Council and Counsel Can Be Related

Although the two concepts are different, they can be connected.

A council may produce counsel.

For example:

Ungodly people gather → they deliberate → they produce ungodly counsel → others follow that counsel.

This creates a relationship between the two concepts.

However, the reverse is also possible:

Ungodly counsel exists → individuals accept it → no formal council is necessary.

Therefore, counsel does not require a council.

A person can encounter ungodly counsel through:

- an individual,
- a friend,
- a teacher,
- a social group,
- a cultural environment,
- literature,
- media,
- philosophy,
- or personal reasoning.

---

11. The Council of Ungodly People as a Social Environment

Although “counsel” is the appropriate lexical concept in Psalm 1:1, the idea of an **ungodly social environment** can still be explored theologically.

People do not develop their beliefs in isolation.

Groups can influence:

- what people consider normal,
- what they consider acceptable,
- what they value,

- what they reject,
- how they speak about God,
- how they respond to godly people,
- and how they respond to moral disagreement.

A group of people can therefore become an environment in which ungodly counsel is repeatedly communicated and reinforced.

In this broader sense, a **council of ungodly people** can be used descriptively to refer to an organized or collective body of people whose deliberation and purposes oppose God's ways.

But this should be clearly identified as a **broader theological or descriptive use**, not as the lexical definition of the Hebrew word in Psalm 1:1.

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12. The Counsel of Ungodly People

The **counsel of ungodly people** is more directly concerned with influence.

It can involve:

12.1 Ungodly advice

A person encourages another to pursue something contrary to God's ways.

12.2 Ungodly values

A group teaches that wealth, pleasure, status, or power should be treated as ultimate.

12.3 Ungodly plans

People develop plans that disregard God's moral purposes.

12.4 Ungodly worldview

A person adopts assumptions that exclude God from the center of life.

12.5 Ungodly social influence

Repeated exposure to ungodly thinking gradually changes a person's attitudes and decisions.

Thus, counsel concerns the **direction in which a person is being influenced**.

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13. Council of Ungodly People and Rejection of God

A council or group of ungodly people may collectively reject God's truth.

This can happen through:

- discussion,
- collective decision-making,
- shared values,
- rejection of Scripture,
- ridicule of religious beliefs,
- or opposition to godly practices.

The group dimension is significant because individuals can reinforce one another.

One person expresses an ungodly opinion.

Another agrees.

A third person strengthens the same position.

Eventually, the group develops a shared environment in which godly truth is dismissed.

This is a **social phenomenon**, whereas the counsel itself is the **guidance or thinking being promoted**.

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14. Counsel and the Individual

The importance of counsel becomes especially clear when considering the individual.

A person may enter an environment where ungodly counsel is repeatedly heard.

At first, the person may simply hear it.

Then the person may consider it.

Eventually, the person may accept it.

After acceptance, the person may begin to act according to it.

The progression can therefore be represented as:

Exposure → consideration → acceptance → influence → action → habit → way of life.

This helps explain why Psalm 1:1 begins with **walking** in counsel.

The issue is not merely hearing ungodly advice.

The deeper issue is **allowing that counsel to determine one's direction**.

---

15. Counsel and Worldly Happiness

This distinction also connects with a broader theological question about happiness.

Ungodly counsel may encourage a person to seek happiness through:

- money,
- wealth,
- possessions,
- sinful pleasure,
- status,
- power,
- or worldly success.

Such counsel can gradually redefine what a person considers valuable.

For example:

“More money will make me secure.”

can become:

“My money is my security.”

And eventually:

“Without my money, I have nothing.”

The counsel has therefore moved from an idea to a foundation of identity and trust.

This demonstrates why counsel can have significant spiritual consequences.

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16. Counsel and Misplaced Trust

Ungodly counsel can also influence what a person trusts.

A person may be encouraged to trust:

- wealth instead of God,
- human wisdom instead of God's wisdom,
- power instead of righteousness,
- pleasure instead of holiness,
- possessions instead of divine provision,
- or personal strength instead of dependence upon God.

The problem is not simply receiving advice.

The deeper problem is allowing the advice to reshape the person's **ultimate trust**.

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17. Council, Counsel, and Godly People

The distinction can also be applied to the relationship between ungodly people and godly people.

An ungodly group may reject godly counsel.

They may refuse advice because it comes from someone who follows God.

In more hostile situations, the rejection can develop into:

- disagreement,
- criticism,
- mockery,
- insults,
- verbal abuse,
- intimidation,
- threats,
- harassment,
- or, in severe circumstances, physical violence.

However, these stages should not be treated as inevitable.

Disagreement is not automatically persecution.

A person can reject Christian teaching while still treating Christians respectfully.

Likewise, an argument is not automatically persecution.

Persecution represents a more serious form of hostility directed against someone because of religious faith, identity, belief, or practice.

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18. A False or Hostile Discussion

A group may appear to be engaging in a discussion about God or Christian truth while actually seeking to ridicule or humiliate a godly person.

This is different from genuine intellectual disagreement.

A genuine discussion can involve:

- questions,
- disagreement,
- examination of evidence,
- respectful criticism,
- and sincere truth-seeking.

A hostile discussion may instead involve:

- ridicule,
- personal insults,
- humiliation,
- deliberate provocation,
- dismissal,
- or intimidation.

The distinction is therefore not simply whether disagreement exists.

The important question is **how the disagreement is conducted and what purpose the interaction serves**.

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19. From Ungodly Counsel to Hostility

An ungodly environment can potentially move from ideas to behavior.

A possible progression is:

Ungodly counsel

↓

Rejection of godly truth

↓

Rejection of godly people

↓

Mockery and ridicule

↓

Insults and verbal abuse

↓

Aggressive opposition

↓

Intimidation or threats

↓

Harassment or suppression

↓

Possible physical violence

↓

Persecution

This progression is a theological model, not a claim that every ungodly person or group will follow all these stages.

The purpose is to distinguish different levels of conduct rather than treating them as identical.

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20. The Difference Between Council and Counsel in This Progression

The distinction can now be stated clearly.

Council

The **council** is the group.

For example:

A group of ungodly people gathers together and discusses how they will respond to Christians.

Counsel

The **counsel** is the guidance, plan, advice, or thinking produced or followed.

For example:

The group develops a plan to reject, ridicule, or oppose godly people.

Thus:

The council may formulate counsel.

But:

The counsel can influence people even without a council.

This distinction prevents the two words from being used interchangeably.

---

21. A Word-Study Conclusion from Psalm 1:1

The Hebrew evidence is particularly important.

Psalm 1:1 uses **עֵצָה (*ʿēṣâ*)**, a Hebrew noun whose semantic range includes counsel, advice, plan, purpose, consultation, and related concepts.

The specific phrase in Psalm 1:1 is therefore about **the counsel of the wicked**, not about a formal “council” in the English sense of an organized assembly.

This means that a study of Psalm 1:1 should begin with:

Counsel of the Ungodly

rather than:

Council of the Ungodly.

A broader study may subsequently examine how ungodly people form communities, groups, or councils that generate and reinforce ungodly counsel.

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22. Comparative Summary

Category	Council of Ungodly People	Counsel of Ungodly People
Basic meaning	A group or assembly	Advice, guidance, plan, or influence
Primary focus	People	Ideas/guidance
Requires a group?	Normally yes	No
Requires a formal meeting?	Not necessarily, but it involves a collective body	No
Can influence an individual?	Yes	Yes
Can produce plans?	Yes	Counsel can include plans
Can promote ungodly values?	Yes	Yes
Relation to Psalm 1:1	Broader application	Direct lexical concept
Hebrew word in Psalm 1:1	Not the primary concept	**עֵצָה (ʿēṣâ)**
Main question	“Who is gathered?”	“What guidance is being followed?”

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23. A Theological Definition

Based on the word study, the following definitions can be used in theological writing.

Council of Ungodly People

A council of ungodly people is a group, assembly, or social body whose members share or promote beliefs, values, purposes, or conduct that reject or disregard God's ways.

This is a descriptive theological expression, not the lexical meaning of the Hebrew term in Psalm 1:1.

Counsel of Ungodly People

The counsel of ungodly people is the advice, guidance, plans, values, ideas, and influence arising from or consistent with an ungodly way of thinking and directing a person away from God's ways.

This corresponds much more directly to the concept expressed by **עֵצָה (*ʿēṣâ*)** in Psalm 1:1.

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24. Final Conclusion

The difference between **council** and **counsel** is small in spelling but significant in meaning.

Council refers to people.

Counsel refers to advice, guidance, plans, or influence.

A council can give counsel.

A person can follow counsel without belonging to a council.

An ungodly council may therefore be understood as a group of ungodly people, while the counsel of the ungodly refers to the ideas, guidance, plans, values, and influence that direct people away from God.

For the study of Psalm 1:1, the distinction is especially important. The Hebrew noun **עֵצָה (*ʿēṣâ*)** means counsel, advice, plan, purpose, or related forms of guidance. Psalm 1:1 uses this word in connection with the wicked.

Therefore, the most precise starting point for a Psalm 1:1 word study is:

“The Counsel of the Ungodly.”

The concept can then be expanded into the broader theological study of how **ungodly counsel may be produced, communicated, accepted, and reinforced within an ungodly social environment**.

The distinction can finally be expressed in one sentence:

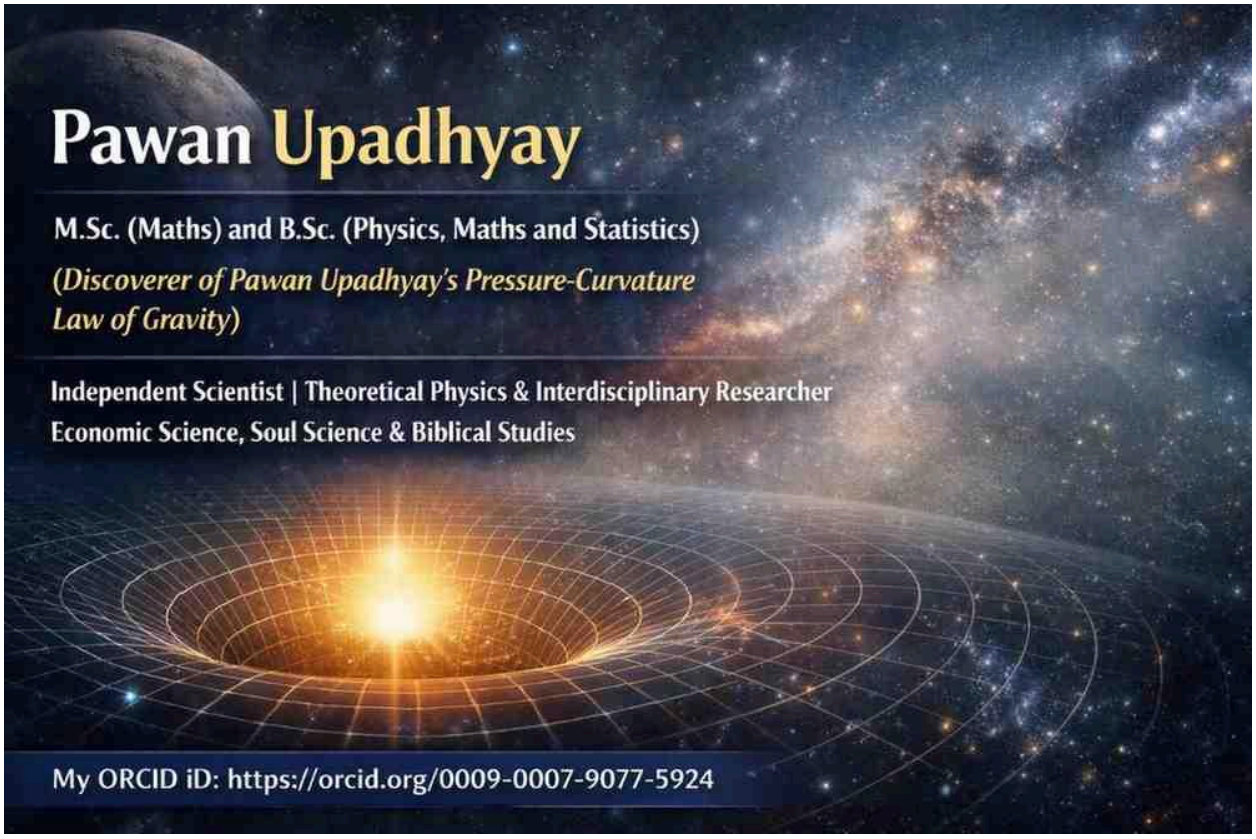
The council describes the people who deliberate; the counsel describes the guidance, plans, values, and influence that are given or followed.

Expanded Research Paper

Council and Counsel

A Theological Word Study of Ungodly People, Influence, and Hostility

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Abstract

The words **council** and **counsel** are closely related in pronunciation but have distinct meanings. *Council* generally refers to a group or assembly of people who gather to deliberate, discuss, advise, or make decisions. *Counsel* refers to advice, guidance, direction, plans, opinions, or influence that can shape a person's thinking and conduct.

This research paper examines these two concepts from an independent Christian theological perspective. It develops a distinction between the **council of ungodly people** and the **counsel of ungodly people**. The council concerns the people or collective environment, while counsel concerns the ideas, advice, values, plans, and influence communicated or followed within that environment.

The paper proposes that an ungodly council can become an environment in which godly truth is rejected, godly people are mocked or insulted, and hostile attitudes are reinforced. Such hostility may sometimes develop from disagreement into aggressive debate, verbal abuse, intimidation, threats, harassment, and, in severe circumstances, physical violence or persecution. However, this progression is not inevitable, and ordinary disagreement should not automatically be classified as persecution.

The paper also examines how ungodly counsel can influence individuals. Advice and values that encourage rejection of God, sinful desires, misplaced trust in wealth, worldly happiness, or

hostility toward godly truth can gradually shape a person's thinking and conduct. The paper concludes by distinguishing the **group that produces or reinforces influence** from the **influence itself**, while emphasizing the Christian response of truth, wisdom, patience, courage, self-control, and faithfulness to God.

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1. Introduction

Human beings are influenced by the people around them.

Families, friends, communities, organizations, social groups, and cultures can shape how people think about God, morality, happiness, wealth, success, suffering, and human relationships.

People do not merely receive information from others. They also receive values, assumptions, attitudes, expectations, and ways of understanding life.

For this reason, the distinction between **council** and **counsel** is important.

A **council** concerns a group of people.

Counsel concerns the advice, guidance, plans, values, or influence that can come from people.

This distinction provides a useful framework for examining what may be called the **council of ungodly people** and the **counsel of ungodly people**.

The purpose of this paper is not to examine a particular biblical verse. Instead, it develops an independent theological framework for understanding:

1. the meaning of council,
2. the meaning of counsel,
3. the nature of an ungodly council,
4. the nature of ungodly counsel,
5. the rejection of godly truth,
6. mockery and insults toward godly people,
7. aggressive debate and hostility,
8. possible progression toward persecution,
9. emotional and psychological suffering,
10. and the appropriate response of godly people.

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2. Meaning of Council

The word **council** refers to a group, assembly, committee, or body of people who gather for discussion, deliberation, advice, or decision-making.

The central idea is **a collective body of people**.

A council may exist for different purposes.

Examples include:

- a governing council,
- an advisory council,
- a religious council,
- a community council,
- a council of elders,
- or an organizational council.

A council may make decisions, develop plans, discuss issues, or determine how a group will respond to a particular situation.

Therefore:

Council primarily refers to the people or collective body.

---

3. Meaning of Counsel

The word **counsel** refers to advice, guidance, direction, recommendation, deliberation, plans, or considered judgment.

The central idea is **guidance or direction**.

Counsel can be:

- wise or foolish,
- godly or ungodly,
- helpful or harmful,
- constructive or destructive.

For example:

“He followed the counsel of his friend.”

In this sentence, counsel means the advice or guidance that influenced the person's decision.

Therefore:

Counsel primarily refers to the advice, guidance, plans, values, or influence.

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4. The Fundamental Difference

The distinction can be summarized simply:

Council is the group. Counsel is the guidance.

A council may give counsel.

Counsel can influence a person even when there is no formal council.

For example:

The council discussed the issue and gave counsel to the community.

Here:

- **council** = the group,
- **counsel** = the advice or guidance.

This distinction should be maintained throughout theological discussion.

---

5. The Council of Ungodly People

The phrase **"council of ungodly people"** can be used to describe a group or collective environment in which people share, reinforce, or promote values and conduct that are contrary to God's ways.

The defining feature is not merely that the people disagree with Christianity.

A group can disagree with Christian beliefs without necessarily being characterized by hostility or ungodliness in every aspect.

The theological concern is a deeper pattern in which the group:

- rejects God's authority,
- disregards godly truth,
- promotes sinful values,
- encourages ungodly conduct,
- ridicules godliness,
- or becomes hostile toward people who faithfully follow God.

Thus:

An ungodly council is a collective environment in which ungodly values, attitudes, purposes, or conduct are shared, reinforced, or promoted.

---

6. The Council as a Social Environment

An ungodly council should not necessarily be imagined as a formal meeting around a table.

The concept can also describe a social environment.

A group of people can function collectively even without formally calling itself a council.

For example, a group of friends may repeatedly:

- ridicule Christian beliefs,
- encourage sinful behavior,
- discourage obedience to God,
- mock people who pray,
- or treat godly values as foolish.

The group has created an environment in which ungodly attitudes are reinforced.

Therefore, the idea of a council can include **collective influence and shared social direction**, not merely a formal organization.

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7. Counsel of Ungodly People

The **counsel of ungodly people** concerns the guidance, values, ideas, opinions, plans, and influence communicated by ungodly people.

This counsel can be direct or indirect.

Direct counsel

Someone may explicitly advise:

“Do what you want. You do not need to obey God.”

Indirect counsel

A group may repeatedly communicate the idea:

“Money, pleasure, and success are what really matter.”

The second example may never be expressed as a formal instruction, but it still communicates a worldview.

Therefore, counsel can influence people through both **words and patterns of thought**.

---

8. Forms of Ungodly Counsel

Ungodly counsel can take many forms.

8.1 Ungodly advice

Advice that encourages behavior contrary to God's ways.

8.2 Ungodly values

Values that place worldly things above God.

8.3 Ungodly plans

Plans that intentionally disregard God's moral purposes.

8.4 Ungodly attitudes

Attitudes that treat sin as acceptable or godliness as unnecessary.

8.5 Ungodly worldview

A way of understanding life that excludes God from His rightful place.

8.6 Ungodly social influence

Repeated exposure to people whose thinking gradually shapes an individual's own beliefs and behavior.

---

9. Ungodly Counsel and the Rejection of God

One possible characteristic of ungodly counsel is the rejection of God.

A person may begin to think:

“I do not need God.”

From there, the person may increasingly depend upon:

- personal strength,
- wealth,
- possessions,
- success,
- pleasure,
- status,
- or human wisdom.

The issue is not simply disagreement with religious belief.

The deeper theological issue is **replacing dependence upon God with dependence upon created things or human wisdom**.

---

10. Ungodly Counsel and Worldly Happiness

Ungodly counsel can also shape a person's understanding of happiness.

A person may be encouraged to believe that happiness comes primarily from:

- money,
- wealth,
- possessions,

- pleasure,
- status,
- power,
- success,
- or social recognition.

Such counsel can gradually change the person's priorities.

The person may begin to think:

“If I have enough money, I will be secure.”

Eventually:

“My money is my security.”

The distinction between possessing wealth and trusting wealth becomes increasingly important.

---

11. Wealth and Misplaced Trust

Wealth is not inherently the same thing as ungodliness.

A person can possess considerable wealth without making wealth the ultimate object of trust.

The theological problem arises when wealth becomes:

- the foundation of identity,
- the source of ultimate security,
- the measure of personal worth,
- the primary source of happiness,
- or a substitute for dependence upon God.

Ungodly counsel can reinforce this misplaced trust.

For example, a person may repeatedly hear that financial success is the highest measure of a meaningful life.

Over time, that message can shape the person's understanding of security and happiness.

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12. Ungodly Counsel and Greed

Greed can develop when the desire for wealth becomes excessive and controlling.

The problem is not simply wanting financial stability.

The problem occurs when the desire for wealth becomes dominant.

A person may move from:

“I need enough to live responsibly.”

to:

“I need more.”

Then:

“I can never have enough.”

Eventually:

“Everything depends upon what I possess.”

Ungodly counsel can reinforce this way of thinking.

The result can be a gradual movement away from contentment and dependence upon God toward excessive attachment to possessions.

---

13. Rejection of Godly Truth

An ungodly council may reject the words or teachings of godly people.

This rejection can occur at different levels.

A person may simply disagree.

Another may question.

Another may reject.

Another may ridicule.

These responses should not automatically be treated as equivalent.

A theological analysis should distinguish between **disagreement, rejection, ridicule, hostility, and persecution**.

Such distinctions prevent the concept of ungodliness from becoming so broad that every disagreement is treated as hostility.

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14. Mockery of Godly People

When an ungodly environment becomes hostile toward godliness, mockery may develop.

Mockery can involve:

- making fun of Christian beliefs,
- ridiculing prayer,
- laughing at religious commitment,
- humiliating a person because of faith,
- or treating godly behavior as foolish.

Mockery is more than disagreement because it introduces contempt or ridicule.

However, mockery and persecution should still be distinguished.

Not every mocking statement constitutes persecution in the fullest sense.

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15. Insults and Verbal Abuse

Hostility can become more personal through insults and verbal abuse.

A person may be attacked because of:

- religious beliefs,
- Christian identity,
- moral convictions,
- commitment to God,
- or refusal to participate in sinful behavior.

Verbal abuse can produce genuine emotional distress.

It can cause:

- humiliation,
- fear,
- anxiety,
- isolation,
- grief,
- loss of confidence,
- and psychological suffering.

Such suffering should not be minimized merely because no physical injury occurred.

---

16. Aggressive Debate

Debate itself is not ungodly.

People can disagree strongly while maintaining respect.

Healthy disagreement can include:

- questions,
- criticism,
- examination of evidence,
- alternative interpretations,
- and reasoned argument.

Aggressive debate is different when the interaction becomes dominated by:

- personal attacks,
- humiliation,
- intimidation,
- shouting,
- threats,
- deliberate provocation,
- or attempts to silence another person.

Aggression can therefore reveal hostility, but it should not automatically be called persecution.

---

17. False or Hostile Discussions

Some discussions may appear to seek truth but actually function as opportunities for ridicule or humiliation.

Such discussions can be described as **false or hostile discussions**.

The distinction is based on purpose and conduct.

A genuine discussion seeks understanding.

A hostile discussion may seek to:

- embarrass,
- ridicule,
- insult,
- provoke,
- silence,
- or discredit.

Therefore, the mere existence of questions does not prove that a conversation is genuinely seeking truth.

---

18. From Rejection to Hostility

In some situations, rejection of godly truth can develop into increasing hostility.

A possible progression is:

Rejection of God

↓

Rejection of godly truth

↓

Rejection of godly counsel

↓

Mockery of godly people

↓

Insults and verbal abuse

↓

Aggressive opposition

↓

Intimidation

↓

Threats

↓

Harassment or suppression

↓

Possible physical violence

↓

Persecution

This progression is **not inevitable**.

It is a theological model describing how hostility may intensify in particular circumstances.

---

19. Physical Violence and Persecution

In severe circumstances, hostility toward godly people can become physical.

A person may be attacked or beaten because of religious faith or because of commitment to God.

Such conduct represents a severe form of persecution.

However, this must be stated carefully.

It would be inaccurate to say:

“Everyone who rejects God will eventually attack godly people.”

That is an unjustified generalization.

The more precise statement is:

In some hostile environments, rejection of godly people can escalate into threats, harassment, or physical violence because of their faith.

---

20. Emotional and Psychological Suffering

Hostility toward godly people can produce serious emotional suffering.

Possible forms include:

- fear,
- anxiety,
- humiliation,
- emotional distress,
- psychological suffering,
- isolation,
- grief,
- and trauma.

The term **“torture”** should be used carefully because it denotes an especially severe form of suffering and can have specific legal and technical meanings.

For ordinary cases of insults, mockery, or verbal hostility, terms such as **emotional distress, psychological suffering, verbal abuse, or psychological abuse** are generally more precise.

---

21. The Relationship Between Council and Counsel

The distinction can now be applied directly to the theological framework.

Council

The council is the **group**.

It represents the people who collectively share, reinforce, discuss, or promote certain values and attitudes.

Counsel

The counsel is the **guidance or influence**.

It represents the ideas, advice, plans, values, and directions communicated or followed.

The relationship can therefore be expressed as:

Council → produces or reinforces → Counsel → influences → Individual → affects → Conduct.

For example:

A group of ungodly people gathers and encourages rejection of God.

The **group** is the council.

The **rejection-oriented advice and worldview** constitute the counsel.

The **individual who accepts it** is influenced by the counsel.

The **resulting behavior** demonstrates the influence of that counsel.

---

22. Council Without Formal Organization

An important qualification is that the term **council** does not always require a formally established organization.

A group can function collectively through shared attitudes and decisions.

For example, a group of people may regularly meet socially and collectively ridicule Christian beliefs.

They may have no official title, constitution, or leadership structure.

Nevertheless, they function as a collective social environment.

In a theological discussion, such a group may be described as an **ungodly council** in a broad descriptive sense.

The term should not, however, be confused with the meaning of **counsel**.

---

23. Counsel Without a Council

The reverse is equally important.

A person can receive ungodly counsel without belonging to an ungodly council.

For example:

- one friend gives ungodly advice,
- a book promotes an ungodly worldview,
- a cultural message glorifies greed,
- an influential person encourages sinful behavior,
- or a social environment repeatedly communicates values contrary to God.

No formal council is required.

Therefore:

Counsel can exist independently of a council.

This is one of the clearest distinctions between the two concepts.

---

24. Theological Response to Ungodly Counsel

The appropriate Christian response is not simply to reject every person who disagrees with Christian belief.

Instead, Christians should exercise discernment.

A person can ask:

- What values are being communicated?
- Does this counsel lead toward or away from God?
- What assumptions about happiness are being promoted?
- What does this advice encourage me to trust?
- Does it encourage sinful behavior?
- Does it reject God's truth?
- Is this genuine disagreement or deliberate hostility?

Such questions help distinguish **discernment from prejudice**.

---

25. The Response to an Ungodly Council

When Christians encounter a hostile group environment, they should not automatically respond with hostility.

A godly response can involve:

- truth,
- wisdom,
- patience,
- courage,
- self-control,
- respectful speech,
- appropriate boundaries,
- and discernment.

If hostility becomes dangerous, seeking safety is appropriate.

A person may leave the situation, establish boundaries, seek support, report threats or violence, and use appropriate legal or community resources.

Faithfulness to God does not require deliberately remaining in unnecessary danger.

---

26. Truth Without Aggression

A Christian can remain committed to truth without becoming aggressive.

The existence of ungodly hostility does not justify hatred.

The Christian response should not simply mirror the behavior being opposed.

Therefore:

Truth does not require aggression, and faithfulness does not require hatred.

A person can firmly reject ungodly counsel while still treating other people with dignity.

---

27. A Conceptual Model

The distinction between council and counsel can be represented as follows:

Council

People → group → shared environment → collective influence

Counsel

Ideas → advice → values → direction → decisions → conduct

Relationship

Ungodly people

↓

Collective environment

↓

Ungodly counsel

↓

Influence on individuals

↓

Ungodly decisions or conduct

↓

Possible rejection of godly truth

↓

Possible hostility toward godly people

↓

In severe circumstances, possible persecution

Again, this is a conceptual model rather than a claim that every group or individual follows the entire sequence.

28. Council and Counsel: Comparative Summary

Feature	Council of Ungodly People	Counsel of Ungodly People
Primary meaning	Group or collective body	Advice, guidance, influence, or plans
Focus	People	Ideas and direction
Requires multiple people?	Normally a collective	Not necessarily
Requires a formal organization?	No	No
Can influence others?	Yes	Yes
Can promote ungodly values?	Yes	Yes
Can reject godly truth?	Yes	Yes
Can produce hostility?	Potentially	Potentially

Can involve mockery?	Potentially	Through the values or attitudes promoted
Can contribute to persecution?	In severe circumstances	Through ideas or guidance that encourage hostility
Main question	“Who forms the group?”	“What guidance is being given or followed?”

---

29. Key Distinction

The most important distinction in this research can be expressed in two sentences:

The council of ungodly people refers to the collective group or social environment of people who share or promote ungodly attitudes, values, purposes, or conduct.

The counsel of ungodly people refers to the advice, guidance, plans, ideas, values, and influence through which ungodly thinking can shape an individual's decisions and conduct.

These two concepts are related but should not be treated as identical.

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30. Conclusion

The distinction between **council** and **counsel** provides a useful framework for understanding the social and theological dimensions of ungodliness.

A **council** is concerned primarily with the **people or collective body**.

Counsel is concerned primarily with the **guidance, advice, plans, values, ideas, and influence** communicated or followed.

An ungodly council can create an environment in which ungodly counsel is produced and reinforced.

Ungodly counsel can then influence individuals by shaping their understanding of God, happiness, wealth, morality, success, and human relationships.

This influence may encourage a person to reject God, pursue sinful desires, place excessive trust in money and possessions, or reject godly truth.

In a hostile environment, rejection can sometimes develop into mockery, insults, verbal abuse, aggressive opposition, intimidation, threats, harassment, and, in severe circumstances, physical violence or persecution.

Yet these developments should not be treated as inevitable.

Disagreement is not automatically hostility.

Hostility is not automatically persecution.

Counsel is not the same as council.

And **a group of ungodly people is not necessarily a formal council**.

The central distinction remains:

Council describes the group; counsel describes the guidance.

Understanding this distinction allows the theological discussion to remain precise while examining how ungodly people, ungodly influence, rejection of godly truth, hostility, and persecution may be related.

Ultimately, the Christian response to ungodly counsel and hostile environments is not to imitate ungodliness, but to remain grounded in truth, wisdom, courage, self-control, and faithfulness to God.